



Trailblazer: Hossam Hassan is the first person to play and coach for Egypt at the World Cup. **Garcia effect:** The 62-year-old Rudi Garcia (above, right), who won the Ligue 1 title with Lille in 2011, was appointed at the start of 2025 and tasked with breathing new life into the Belgian team after the tenure of Domenico Tedesco. ^{AP}

controversial Round of 16 loss against Argentina, with Hossam fearlessly accusing FIFA of favouritism towards the defending champion and its talisman, Lionel Messi.

But perhaps his most lasting contribution came when he used the World Cup campaign to speak up about the suffering of the Palestinians while others shied away from such topics, stating, "Regardless of religion. ... I am a human before being Arab or anything else. My message, through football, is this: Please, just as FIFA's slogan calls for respect among us, I hope there will be respect for people's right to live."

While these heroes of days gone by orchestrated memorable campaigns for their respective nations, Belgium found its unheralded guide in Frenchman Rudi

Garcia. Following the squad's lacklustre spell under previous manager Domenico Tedesco, Garcia was tasked with ushering Belgium beyond its ageing 'Golden Generation.'

Instead of chasing a wholesale overhaul, Garcia drew on his experience of managing clubs across Europe and adopted a pragmatic approach that helped Belgium surpass all expectations.

His courage in decision-making was evident during Belgium's Round of 32 fixture against Senegal. Trailing by two goals, Garcia withdrew two of his biggest names, Kevin De Bruyne and Jeremy Doku, in the 56th minute. The Europeans went on to complete a stunning comeback, with the substitutions proving decisive.

In the end, however, Garcia's boldness also proved his undoing. In the quarterfinal against Spain, he

chose to finish the match with Senne Lammens in goal instead of an ailing Thibaut Courtois, only for the former to commit the costly error that handed Spain victory. Even in defeat, Garcia remained poised and proud of how his players had carried themselves throughout the tournament. He had shown that, with the right people calling the shots, Belgium could finally stop lamenting the greatness of its past and begin looking towards a new era.

That promise, however, will not be his to fulfil. It has now emerged that Garcia will leave his role after the Belgian football association decided against extending his contract.

Ultimately, all the plaudits will go to those who toil on the green grass and, to some extent, quite rightfully so. But amid the celebrations, the architects behind the chaos must not fade into the background.